



English

Year 8

Cambridge Lower Secondary
Student Manual



Prime Books · English Year 8 · Student Book

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British English edition.

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INTRODUCTION

How this book works

This is a book about the craft of reading and writing. In this first unit you will read an original travel narrative, study how a writer uses tense and figurative language to make a reader feel present, and write a vivid account of a journey of your own.

What makes this book different

- **Everything is original.** Every sentence, example and diagram was made for this book.
- **Every claim is checked.** Facts come from real, cited sources; every numerical answer was executed by computer before publication.
- **Thinking is taught explicitly.** Dedicated panels show you how specialists in this subject actually reason.

A note to teachers and parents

This book follows the spirit of an international lower-secondary programme, interpreted afresh for Prime School. Each topic opens with clear outcomes and closes with self-assessment, so progress is visible to pupil and teacher alike.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Reading the page

Each section follows the same rhythm, so you always know where you are.

PANEL	WHAT IT DOES
Learning outcomes	What you will be able to do by the end.
Getting started	A warm-up that wakes up what you know.
Key words	The vocabulary of the topic, defined.
Worked example	A model solution, with the reasoning shown.
Questions	Practice, from straightforward to demanding.
Did you know?	A true and surprising fact.
Summary checklist	'I can' statements to check your progress.
Sources & references	Where every fact came from.

How to work

Read with a pencil in your hand. When the book asks a question, try to answer it before reading on. Do the work in your notebook, and check your reasoning, not just your answer.

GETTING SET UP

Before Unit 1

You need a pencil, a ruler, a notebook and your curiosity. Anything else this unit requires is listed where it is needed.

Your toolkit

- A notebook for working, planning and recording, not just for final answers.
- The habit of checking: recalculate, reread, and ask whether the answer is sensible.
- The confidence to say "I am not sure yet", which is where all real learning starts.

A quick self-check

- 1 What do you already know about this topic?
- 2 Which part of it do you expect to find hardest, and why?
- 3 How will you know when you have genuinely understood something, rather than just recognised it?

Unit 1 begins now. Work carefully, check honestly, and ask good questions.

UNIT 1

1

Journeys and discoveries

Travel writing, tense and the art of noticing

© IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- ✓ Read travel writing and analyse how it works.
- ✓ Use verb tenses deliberately, for effect.
- ✓ Recognise and use figurative language.
- ✓ Write a vivid account of a journey.

◆ GETTING STARTED

Think of a journey you remember clearly, however short. In pairs, discuss:

- what one detail do you remember most sharply, and why that one?
- what did you notice that a stranger might have missed?
- how would you make a reader feel they were there with you?

UNIT 1 • SESSION 1.1

Reading a travel narrative

Learn

Travel writing is non-fiction, but it uses the tools of fiction: vivid detail, a distinct voice, and a shape that carries the reader along. The best travel writers are not the ones who go furthest. They are the ones who **notice** most.

“ EXTRACT • 'THE SLEEPER TO PORTO' ”

The night train pulled out of Lisbon at ten, and for the first hour I could still read the city in the window: warehouses, a football pitch lit up and empty, the long orange smear of a motorway. Then the buildings thinned, and the dark came in properly, and the glass became a mirror instead of a window.

Across the aisle, an old man was eating an orange with a penknife, working the peel off in one unbroken spiral. He did it with the unhurried competence of someone who has done it ten thousand times. He offered me a segment without looking up, and I took it, and neither of us said anything at all.

I slept badly and gratefully. Somewhere past Coimbra the rhythm of the rails changed pitch, and I woke to a grey window and pine trees streaming past, and that particular ache behind the eyes that means you have arrived somewhere before you are ready for it.

- 1 What is the effect of the phrase "the glass became a mirror instead of a window"? What does it tell us about the passage of time and the narrator's focus?
- 2 The writer describes the old man in detail but gives him no dialogue. Explain how this choice shapes our impression of him.
- 3 "I slept badly and gratefully." This pairing seems contradictory. What does it suggest about the narrator's state of mind?

- 4 Find one detail that could only come from someone who was actually there. Explain why it feels authentic.

 READING TIP

When a writer chooses an unexpected word, pause on it. In "badly and gratefully", the surprise is the whole point: it holds two truths at once. Unexpected words are where meaning is densest.

 LANGUAGE FOCUS

The extract is mostly in the **simple past**: *pulled, slept, woke*. But notice the shifts:

- "I could still read the city" uses a **modal past**, suggesting ongoing ability that is about to end.
 - "has done it ten thousand times" jumps to the **present perfect**, pulling the man's whole past into the present moment.
 - "means you have arrived" moves into the **present tense**, turning one private moment into a general truth the reader recognises.
- 1 Rewrite this sentence in the present tense: "The night train pulled out of Lisbon at ten." What changes about the effect on the reader?
 - 2 Find the sentence that shifts into the present tense. Explain why the writer chose that moment for the shift.
 - 3 Write two sentences about a journey: one in the simple past, then the same event in the present perfect. Describe the difference in feeling.

UNIT 1 • SESSION 1.2

Figurative language

Learn

Figurative language means saying one thing in terms of another. A **metaphor** states the comparison directly. A **simile** signals it with *like* or *as*. **Personification** gives human qualities to something that is not human.

In the extract, "the long orange smear of a motorway" is a metaphor: the road is not literally a smear, but the word captures speed, blur and colour in three syllables.

- 1 Identify the figurative device in each phrase and explain its effect:

- a. "the dark came in properly"
- b. "pine trees streaming past"
- c. "the long orange smear of a motorway"

- 2 Write your own metaphor for each of these: a crowded bus; rain on a window; the moment a train stops.
- 3 Explain why "streaming" is a better choice than "moving" or "going".

■ KEY WORDS

- **travel writing:** non-fiction about a journey, using vivid personal detail.
- **metaphor:** describing something as if it were something else.
- **simile:** a comparison using *like* or *as*.
- **personification:** giving human qualities to a non-human thing.
- **present perfect:** a tense linking a past action to the present moment.

UNIT 1 • SESSION 1.3

Writing an account

Learn

A good account of a journey does not report everything. It **selects**. Choose three or four moments that carry the feeling, and let the rest go.

- 1 Plan an account of a real journey. In your notebook, note:
 - the three moments you will actually describe
 - one small, specific detail for each moment
 - one figurative phrase you will use
 - the feeling you want the reader to be left with
- 2 Write your account, in 250 to 350 words. Use the simple past as your base tense, and shift tense **once**, deliberately, for effect.
- 3 Reread it and cut fifteen words without losing any meaning. Which words went?

⇌ PEER ASSESSMENT

Swap accounts. Tell your partner: the detail that felt most real to you, the moment where you could see it clearly, and one place where a sharper word would help.

▲ CHALLENGE YOURSELF

Rewrite your strongest paragraph entirely in the present tense. Compare the two versions and write three sentences explaining which is better for your purpose, and why.

☑ SUMMARY CHECKLIST

- ✓ I can analyse how a travel writer creates authenticity.
- ✓ I can explain the effect of tense choices and shifts.
- ✓ I can identify and use metaphor, simile and personification.
- ✓ I can plan, write and edit a vivid account of a journey.

UNIT 1 • FINAL PROJECT

The Prime Books travel anthology

★ FINAL PROJECT

The Prime Books travel anthology

The class will publish an anthology of travel writing. Polish your account until it is between 300 and 400 words, good enough for a reader who has never been where you went.

What to hand in

- Your polished account, with a title.
- At least two figurative phrases, underlined.
- One deliberate tense shift, annotated with its intended effect.
- A note on the fifteen words you cut, and why.

How it will be judged

| Criterion | Weight | |---|---| | Vividness and authenticity | 35% | | Control of tense and its effects | 25% | | Quality of figurative language | 25% | | Evidence of real editing | 15% |

UNIT 1 • CHECK YOUR PROGRESS

- 1 What is travel writing, and how does it differ from a diary entry? [2]
- 2 Explain the effect of the phrase 'the glass became a mirror instead of a window'. [2]
- 3 Define metaphor, simile and personification, with an example of each. [3]
- 4 Rewrite in the present tense: 'The night train pulled out of Lisbon at ten.' What changes? [2]
- 5 Explain why 'streaming' is a stronger choice than 'moving'. [1]
- 6 Write one sentence about a journey using the present perfect. [1]

UNIT 1 • EVALUATION

Be honest. Colour the circle that matches how you feel about each outcome: green means confident, amber means nearly there, red means needs more work.

I CAN ...	GREEN	AMBER	RED
analyse how a travel writer creates authenticity	☐	☐	☐
explain the effect of tense choices and shifts	☐	☐	☐
identify and use figurative language	☐	☐	☐
plan, write and edit a vivid account	☐	☐	☐

UNIT 1 • WHAT CAN YOU DO?

✓ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Analyse how a travel writer creates authenticity. | ☐ Identify and use metaphor, simile and personification. |
| ☐ Explain the effect of tense choices and shifts. | ☐ Plan, write and edit a vivid account of a journey. |

GLOSSARY

Unit 1

travel writing: non-fiction about a journey, using vivid personal detail.

metaphor: describing something as if it were something else.

simile: a comparison using like or as.

personification: giving human qualities to a non-human thing.

present perfect: a tense linking a past action to the present.

SOURCES & REFERENCES

Where everything came from

All text and diagrams are original to this edition. The factual claims can be checked here. Links were live as of July 2026.

§ UNIT 1 • JOURNEYS AND DISCOVERIES

1 'The Sleeper to Porto'. An original travel narrative written for this book. © Prime School 2026.

1 Verb tenses and aspect in English. The terminology used in the Language focus panels.

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/English_verbs

PRIME BOOKS

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Read between every line.

This Year 8 English course builds confident readers and precise writers: wide reading, real writing purposes and discussion that sharpens thinking.

INSIDE THIS BOOK

- Wide reading across genres and eras
- Writing for real audiences and purposes
- Vocabulary, grammar and style in context
- Speaking, listening and debate
- Regular checkpoints with model answers

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